

Introduction to Einstein's General Relativity

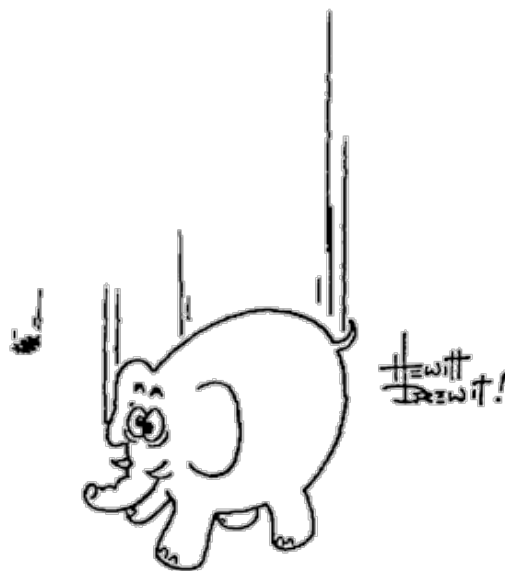
Mustafa A. Amin¹

Department of Physics & Astronomy, Rice University, Houston, Texas 77005-1827, U.S.A.

Abstract

These are Lecture Notes for PHYS 413/513 at Rice University. At the moment, they constitute a work in progress. Please report any typos/errors to mustafa.a.amin@rice.edu.

Last update: August 26, 2026 — 3:05 (Houston)



¹mustafa.a.amin@gmail.com

Preface

These are notes for a one semester course, PHYS 413/513, at Rice University. The course is meant for students (undergraduate and graduate) who have little or no prior exposure to Einstein's General Relativity. However, the students are expected to have a solid foundation in classical mechanics (with Lagrangians), multivariable calculus, differential equations, and linear algebra. Familiarity with Special Relativity and Electrodynamics will be very helpful too.

Students: Do the recommended reading before class!

Acknowledgements

The primary textbook for the course is James Hartle's "Gravity". The notes rely partly on the textbook for organization, and are very much a work in progress. Don't expect complete notes at the moment. I have added my own examples, explanations and visualizations. where I thought I had something to say which can help students further. I will also supplement these notes with exercises to be done as you read through. This will all happen in due time.

I learnt General Relativity first by reading Sean Carroll's more mathematical textbook, which I thoroughly enjoyed. I was enamoured by the elegant differential geometry at the time, but missed some of the relevant physics in that first pass. Hartle's book helped address that for me. I have also benefited from Misner, Thorne and Wheeler's "Gravitation", Weinberg's presentation in "Gravitation and Cosmology" and Wald's book "General Relativity". More recently, I have enjoyed learning from the Special and General Relativity sections of Thorne and Blandford's "Modern Classical Physics".

I owe an immense gratitude to my teachers – Prof. Eva Silverstein who first asked me to learn GR during a "rotation" during the first year of graduate school, Prof. Renata Kallosh for my first course, and Prof. Robert Wagoner for letting me TA for his GR class. This is how I learnt GR during graduate school. Prof. Barbara Shipman at the University of Texas at Arlington taught me multivariable Calculus and Linear Algebra, and then differential Geometry during my undergraduate years, both in class and often on Friday afternoons beyond class. Her enthusiasm for and pedagogy was infectious, and I hope I can follow in her footsteps.

And, importantly, the previous Phys 413/513 students at Rice were critical in making the course what it is now.

CONTENTS

1	Invitation	1
2	Geometry as Physics	1

CHAPTER 1

INVITATION

We will explore one of the most impressive achievements of our species. Along the way, I will also tell you how to lose some weight.

Launch a coconut and a tomato with the same velocity from the earth's surface. In absence of air resistance, they will follow the same trajectory!¹ This, in itself is surprising – the trajectory is independent of their mass. If you were launched with them with the same velocity, they would simply appear to float next to you – gravity seems to have disappeared! More generally, if you were falling freely under gravity, by looking at the tomato and coconut (for a short enough period of time) they would each appear to be moving at a constant velocity, with no gravitational acceleration. Even if you, the coconut and tomato were launched with different individual initial velocities, you would still find that they appear to move at a constant velocity relative to you and each other. You will also “feel” weightless.

Exercise 1.0.1 Why is it surprising that in the gravitational field $\mathbf{g}$ the coconut and tomato, which have different masses m_c and m_t , follow the same trajectory? Consider the situation where the (approximately) constant gravitational field $\mathbf{g}$ near the earth surface is replaced by a constant electric field $\mathbf{E}$, and assume that the fruits have charges q_c and q_e . The accelerations would be $\mathbf{a}_c \propto q_c/m_c$, and similarly $\mathbf{a}_t \propto q_t/m_t$. It depends on the ratio q_i/m_i , ie. on the nature of the bodies, so the trajectories will be different! However, in the case of gravity, $\mathbf{a}_{c,t} = \mathbf{g}$ independent of the mass! Check these statements using Newton's second law, as well as gravitational and electrostatic forces.

Exercise 1.0.2 Suppose that the fruit were launched from the surface of the earth with velocity $\mathbf{v}_c$ and $\mathbf{v}_t$. They will follow parabolic trajectories $\mathbf{x}_c(t)$ and $\mathbf{x}_t(t)$, with velocity $\mathbf{v}_c(t)$ and $\mathbf{v}_t(t)$ and acceleration $\mathbf{a}_c(t) = \mathbf{a}_t(t) = \mathbf{g}$. Write down $\mathbf{x}_{c,t}(t)$ and $\mathbf{v}_{c,t}(t)$. Now imagine at the same time, a platypus named Polly starts falling freely from some height h , write down $\mathbf{x}_P(t), \mathbf{v}_P(t)$ and $\mathbf{a}_P(t)$. What would the position, velocity and acceleration of the coconut and tomato be as measured in the “falling frame” of Polly? You should find that $\mathbf{g}$ disappears; Polly will conclude there is no gravity in the situation.

While not obvious to us on earth easily (unless you are the the unfortunate falling Polly), get in touch with your favorite “freely falling” astronaut in the international space station to understand how

¹Check out a version of this experiment on the moon <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KDpitiUsZw8>. Also see <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=E43-CfukEgs>.

gravitational effects (mostly) disappear for them in their “local” laboratory on the space-station.²

With Einstein as our guide, these simple observations lead us to an astonishing insight into Nature. Gravity is unlike other known forces – it is really about the nature of space and time. Three dimensional space is not a passive arena in which events take place in time, but space and time together – *spacetime* – is an active, dynamical entity. It is a smooth collection of events: a 3+1 dimensional spacetime, whose geometry is determined by the mass-energy within it. The mass of the earth “curves” the spacetime around it.

As we will learn, despite the parabolic locus of the trajectory in space, the coconut and tomato are moving in this curved *spacetime* on the “straightest” possible path which is independent of the composition and mass of the fruit. Gravity is a manifestation of this curved spacetime. We will spend much of the course

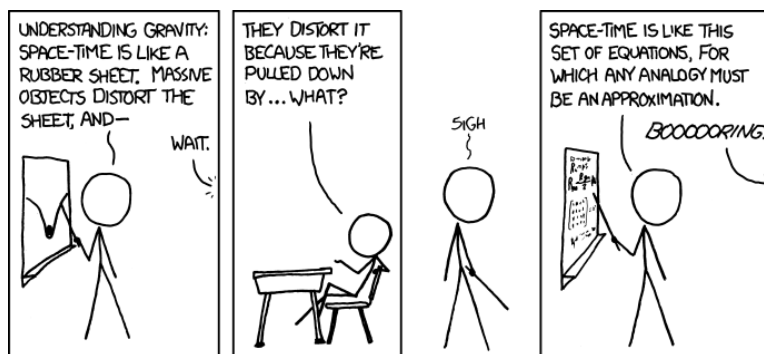


Figure 1.1: Credit: <https://xkcd.com>

developing a quantitative, calculable and testable understanding of the above ideas. This understanding will allow us to appreciate (aspects of) the working of the Global Positioning System (GPS) relevant for your smart phones to help you orient yourself. Moving further out from our abode on our remarkable third rock from the sun, we will learn how the geometric understanding of spacetime explains the puzzling orbit of Mercury around the sun, and the observed deflection of light by the sun.³ It also describes why we can occasionally see the same supernova go off multiple times – seeing the “echoes” of the same explosion. We will be able to describe the formation and environment of spectacular ultra-compact “objects”, neutron stars and black holes in our cosmos. We will be able to understand how a dance of their binaries generate ripples in our dynamical spacetime, which have now been detected on our rock.⁴ Time-permitting we will also touch upon how the evolution of the universe as a whole relies on our understanding of the laws governing a dynamical spacetime.

Our underlying theoretical framework is that of Einstein’s General Theory of Relativity (GR). This theory, arguably one of humanity’s most elegant and well tested ideas, is built upon Einstein’s Special Theory of Relativity. We will review Einstein’s Special Theory of Relativity (SR) first – with an emphasis on geometry. The path to GR then is a matter of living with SR “locally” in small enough regions of spacetime, and developing an understanding of how to connect the happenings in many such small regions together. We will compare and contrast our developing understanding of GR with Newtonian

²In 2024, I read a sign at the Johnson Space Center (inside the mock shuttle), which said astronauts float because of lack of earth’s gravity since they are far away from the earth. After this course, you should tell me what you think about this statement.

³Light deflection from the sun was first observed during a total solar eclipse of 1919. For a bit of history and its significance, you might like a talk I gave on this in the context of the solar eclipse that was viewable from the continental US in 2024. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=D1LGSSoLfNg>.

⁴See <https://www.nobelprize.org/prizes/physics/2017/press-release/>.

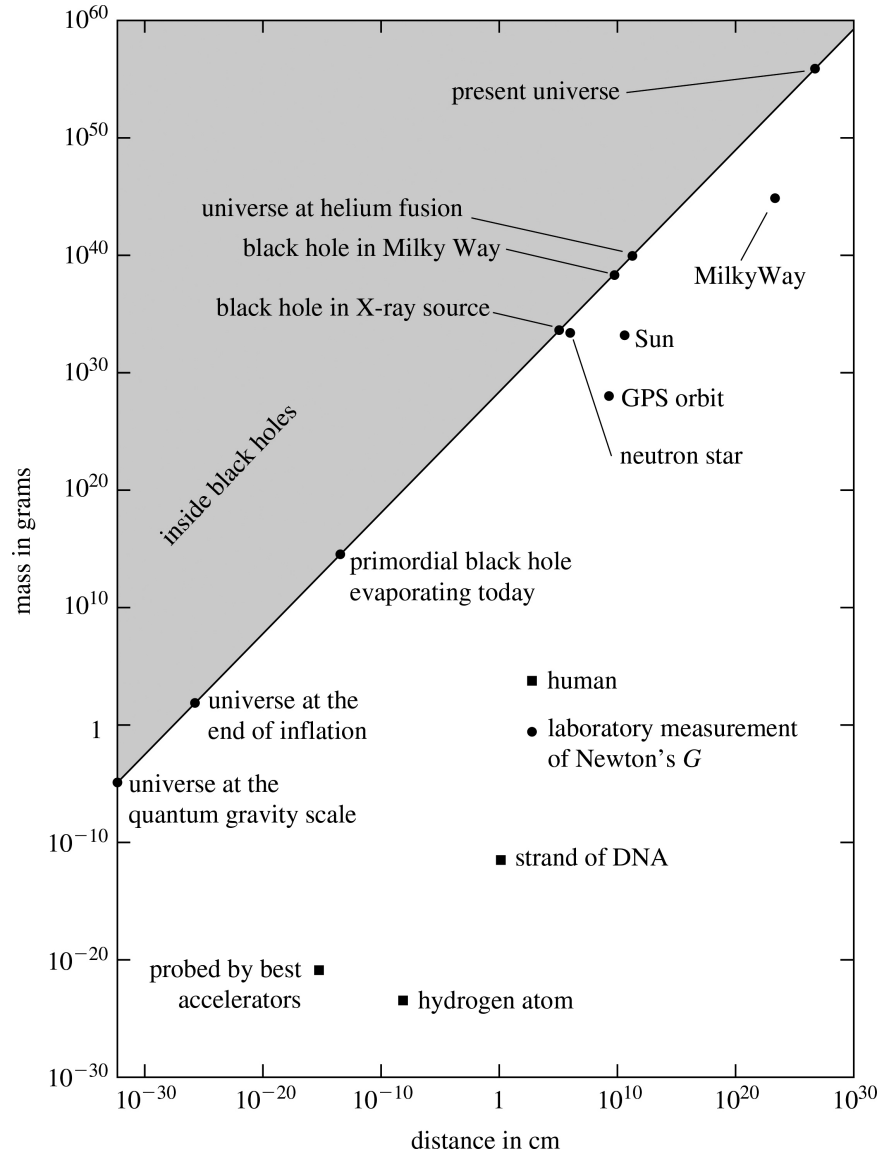


Figure 1.2: General relativity effects are not ignorable near the diagonal line, where $2GM/Rc^2 = 1$. Figure from J. Hartle. To understand the diagonal line, recall that the escape velocity from the surface of a body of mass M and radius R is $v_{\text{esc}} = \sqrt{2GM/R}$. When M and R are such that this escape velocity $v_{\text{esc}} \rightarrow c$, even light cannot escape from its surface (this is the line $M = (c^2/2G)R$). This is the historical definition of a “black hole” (Michell & Laplace, 18th century).

ideas of gravity, and see why Newtonian ideas fail to be consistent with SR and more importantly, with observational and experimental tests.

The Newtonian theory of gravity is of course still extremely useful and accurate for most applications on the earth, solar system and in astrophysics more generally. However, Newtonian gravity fails when considering systems with mass M and extent R , such that GM/Rc^2 becomes order unity. Here $c = 3 \times 10^{10} \text{ cm s}^{-1}$ is the speed of light in vacuum and $G = 6.67 \times 10^{-8} \text{ dyne gm}^{-2} \text{ cm}^2$ is Newton’s gravitational constant. Near a Black Hole, $GM/Rc^2 \sim 1$, neutron star $\sim 10^{-1}$, near the sun (say at the orbital radius of mercury) it is $\sim 10^{-8}$ and $\sim 10^{-6}$ near the sun’s surface, whereas near the earth’s surface $GM/Rc^2 \sim 10^{-9}$.

Note that near the earth and the sun, the precision of the measurements is sufficiently high that even for such small values of GM/Rc^2 , we need to take deviations from Newtonian gravity into account. See Fig. 1.2 to get a feel for where different objects lie in the size-mass plane, and where how far they are from the $GM/Rc^2 \sim 1$ region.

It is very useful to remember that for the sun $GM_{\odot}/c^2 \sim 1$ km, where $M_{\odot} \sim 2 \times 10^{30}$ kg.

Exercise 1.0.3 Estimate $GM/(Rc^2)$ for (i) a proton (ii) human (iii) moon (iv) earth (v) sun (vi) neutron star.

Let us also put general relativity in the context of classical and quantum mechanics. A nice visual way is via the “cube of physics”, see Fig. 1.3. You should read this as, for example, when G becomes more relevant, then Newtonian gravity plays a prominent role. We will not have much to say about when quantum gravity in this course. It becomes important at the Big Bang and near the center of black holes. Notice the physical scale where quantum gravitational effects need to be taken into account. For this course, we will restrict ourselves to classical gravity.

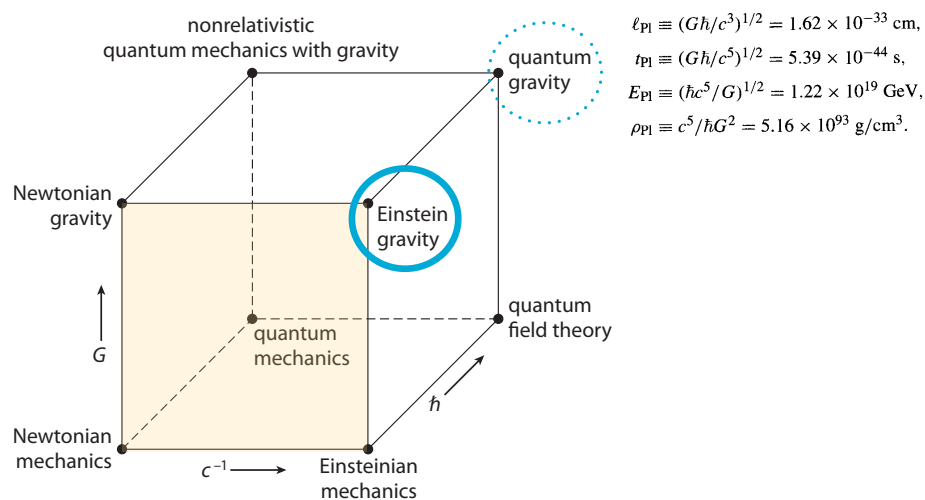


Figure 1.3: Cube of Physics, adapted from A. Zee.

CHAPTER 2

GEOMETRY AS PHYSICS

Gravity is Geometry Considerations of universal free-fall, amongst other things, eventually led Einstein to the profound insight that gravity is not a force; it is a manifestation of the *geometry of spacetime*. He was helped by the fact that his Special Theory of Relativity (ignoring gravitational effects), initially formulated in terms of transformation laws between different observers, had already been geometrized by Minkowski.¹ This geometry, whether in SR or GR, is $3 + 1$ dimensional (3 spatial and 1 temporal dimension), and it is non-Euclidean. It is this “curved” non-Euclidean geometry that encodes gravitational effects.

Geometry of space is something accessible to experimental verification. I encourage you to learn about Gauss’s failed attempt to do so in the vicinity of earth. And then learn about our very successful attempt to do so in the context of cosmology. Both are described in Chapter 2 of Hartle.

To understand “curved” non-Euclidean geometry, let us first restrict ourselves to spatial geometries (as opposed to spacetime geometry). To make things easier still, let us consider 2 dimensional spatial geometries. While we will start with just curved space for pedagogy, ultimately we care about curved spacetime when thinking about gravitational physics.

2d Euclidean An example of a Euclidean 2-dimensional geometry is a 2-dimensional plane. Euclid’s axioms are satisfied on a plane. For example, (i) parallel lines do not intersect, (ii) sums of interior angles of a triangle made of straight lines is π radians and (iii) the ratio of the circumference of a circle to its radius is 2π .

2d non-Euclidean An example of a non-Euclidean 2-dimensional geometry is a 2-sphere (with radius a). Euclid’s axioms are not satisfied on a 2-sphere. For example, (i) parallel lines (say two longitudes which are parallel at the equator) do intersect, (ii) sums of interior angles of a triangle made of straight lines (great circles) is $> \pi$ radians ($\pi + A/a^2$), where A is the area of the triangle on the 2-sphere) and (iii) the ratio of the circumference of a circle to its radius is $< 2\pi$. That is, $\text{circumference}(C)/\text{radius}(r) = 2\pi \sin(r/a)/(r/a)$ where r is the radius of the circle on the 2-sphere.

Note that these properties can be tested by a bug living on the surface of the sphere, without ever leaving the surface. These are “intrinsic” properties of the surface, not requiring any information beyond the surface itself. For example, a bug could take a small segment of a string, and attach one end at some point on the sphere. Then crawl away till the string becomes taut. The bug would measure this taut length in terms of their own tiny steps. This is a radius r in units of their step size. Now, the bug can walk around keeping the string taut to measure trace out a circle on the sphere. Again, the circumference

¹Einstein initially resisted this geometrization of Special Relativity.

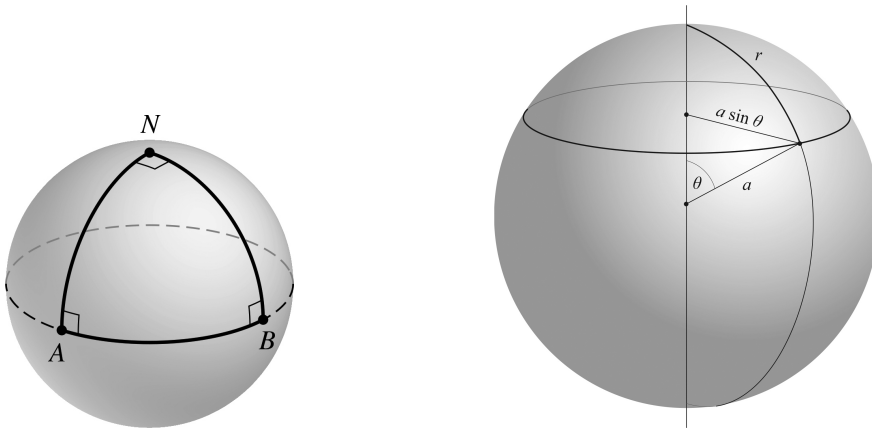


Figure 2.1: Left: The sum of the interior angles of a triangle ABN on a 2-sphere is $> \pi$, in this particular case it is $3\pi/2$. Right: The circumference of the circle of radius r is $< 2\pi r$, it is $C = 2\pi r \sin(r/a)/(r/a)$.

C can be measured in terms of the number of their tiny steps. By comparing the circumference to the radius, the bug would discover that they were living in a non-Euclidean geometry. They never had to see the embedded 2-sphere in 3d Euclidean space by flying out of the surface!

Exercise 2.0.1 Calculate the area of a circle of radius r (distance from the center to the circumference) in the two-dimensional geometry given by the surface of a sphere of radius a . Show that this reduces to πr^2 when $r \ll a$.

3d Euclidean and non-Euclidean Our usual Euclidean 3d space is the obvious generalization of a plane from 2 to 3d. A 3-sphere is a 3d generalization of the 2-sphere. It is also non-Euclidean. For example the volume enclosed by a 2-sphere of radius r in this 3-sphere geometry is

$V = 4\pi a^3 \left[\frac{1}{2} \sin^{-1}(r/a) - (r/2a) \{1 - (r/a)^2\}^{1/2} \right]$. In the limit $r/a \ll 1$, this volume approaches its Euclidean counterpart $V = 4\pi r^3/3 [1 + \mathcal{O}(r^2/a^2)]$.

Specifying a geometry How does one specify a geometry? A convenient and general way to do this is to define a rule for determining distances between nearby points. This is called a metric. Once this rule is specified, lengths of curves can be calculated by adding up such small distances. “Straight” lines can now be defined as curves with extremal lengths between two points. Circles (or spherical surfaces) can be defined as the locus of all points equidistant from a given point, angles can be defined as ratios of some arclength of a circle to the radius, and so on. This way of defining a geometry has significant advantages over trying to describe a geometry by embedding it in some higher dimensional Euclidean space or specifying it with a set of axioms. Both of these get cumbersome and difficult as we move to general geometries which do not have high degree of symmetry.

If the distances along the surface between all nearby cities of the earth were given, you would have been able to tell that the earth is not a plane. Indeed, if someone told you all the distances between any 4 four non-collinear cities, you would know that the surface of the earth is not planar. Please inform your Flat-Earther buddies.

Labelling and Calculating with Co-ordinates in 2 and 3d spaces Co-ordinates are labels of points in a geometry. For example, in a 2d plane, one can label points using the usual Cartesian co-ordinates (x, y) . One could also label points using polar co-ordinates (r, θ) . Different co-ordinates can be

chosen to label points in the same geometry. Different co-ordinate systems are connected by a co-ordinate transformation. For example, $x = r \cos \theta$ and $y = r \sin \theta$.

The square of the distance, ds^2 , between nearby points in a plane with labels (x, y) and $(x + dx)$ or (r, θ) and $(r + dr, \theta + d\theta)$

$$ds^2 = dx^2 + dy^2 = dr^2 + r^2 d\theta^2. \quad (2.0.1)$$

For a 3d Euclidean, the distance between nearby points (x, y, z) and $(x + dx, y + dy, z + dz)$ or equivalently, (r, θ, ϕ) and $(r + dr, \theta + d\theta, \phi + d\phi)$ is

$$ds^2 = dx^2 + dy^2 + dz^2 = dr^2 + r^2(d\theta^2 + \sin^2 \theta d\phi^2). \quad (2.0.2)$$

The different co-ordinate systems are connected by $x = r \sin \theta \cos \phi$, $y = r \sin \theta \sin \phi$ and $z = r \cos \theta$.

Similarly, for a non-Euclidean geometry like a 2-sphere of radius a , a convenient choice of co-ordinates are the latitudes and longitudes (θ, ϕ) . The distance between nearby points (θ, ϕ) and $\theta + d\theta, \phi + d\phi$ is

$$ds^2 = a^2(d\theta^2 + \sin^2 \theta d\phi^2). \quad (2.0.3)$$

For a 3-sphere of radius a , the distance between nearby points (ψ, θ, ϕ) and $(\psi + d\psi, \theta + d\theta, \phi + d\phi)$ is

$$ds^2 = a^2[d\psi^2 + \sin^2 \psi(d\theta^2 + \sin^2 \theta d\phi^2)]. \quad (2.0.4)$$

Note that this square of small distances can be conveniently written as $ds^2 = \sum_{i=1}^3 \sum_{j=1}^3 g_{ij} dx^i dx^j$ where $x^1 = \psi$, $x^2 = \theta$ and $x^3 = \phi$, where $g_{11} = a^2$, $g_{22} = \sin^2 \psi$, $g_{33} = \sin^2 \psi \sin^2 \theta$ with all other $g_{ij} = 0$ (the off-diagonal terms need not always be zero). We will use a simplified notation $ds^2 = g_{ij} dx^i dx^j$, where summation over repeated upstairs and down stairs indices is implied.